Extended Essay in Visual Arts

Title:

Video Games As An Art Form

Research Question:

To What Extent Does The Game 'Control' Use Brutalism To Create A Surreal Visual Experience For Its Viewers?

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Introduction

The 20th century began with a new wave of inspiration, with a series of art movements questioning the world around them and breaking away from classical and orthodox traditions. Artists began looking towards the middle working class, choosing to depict the 'modern life'. The introduction of the camera allowed artists to shift away from realism and prompted the birth of a new generation of ideas. Artists were no longer under the obligation to depict reality as they saw it, and art now became a medium for new philosophies, identities, cultures, and emotions. This initial spark steered the visual medium on a course that today has transformed itself into a method of expression and most importantly today, entertainment.[1]

Pop culture became a key theme of the art world during the 1950s and '60s, especially in the US, with a booming post-war economy, and a middle class with a higher purchasing power. Once again, artists reflected the society around them, becoming a critique of the rampant consumer culture which in turn gave rise to 'mass media'. Every staple item in households now had a brand, and an image tied to it, and art became mass-produced and easy to consume. Artists such as Andy Warhol recognised these changes, such as in his 1962 'Campbell's Tomato Soup' series.[2] Pop art marked another shift in the timeline of art, as it

[1]Graham-Dixon, A. 2019, Andrew The Story of Painting: How Art was Made, Pages 280-283
[2] Museum of Modern Art, Campbell's Soup Cans -Andy Warhol, [Accessed 30th October 2021], https://www.moma.org/learn/moma_learning/andy-warhol-campbells-soup-cans-1962/

now moved to a period where the notions of high art were slowly being abandoned, and the audience for art shifted more towards entertaining the masses.[3]

With the transition into the digital age, art once again evolved, this time losing its physical restrictions, and artists were given a whole new medium to explore. From digital collages to animation, it once again allowed artists to challenge the ideas of what qualified as art. My earliest experiences with art began with video games, and over time I have had emotional experiences with them and realised their significance in their design and the exploration of various themes.

For the Extended Essay, I decided I wanted to formally analyse artistic themes and elements in video games, and for me, the most impactful in this area was the video game 'Control' where I explore its connection to Brutalist architecture and surrealist themes, and how they play into creating a virtual experience for its viewers. Most of the sources come from articles that study the theories of art and its processes, however, accessing sources for the game itself was difficult as there wasn't much study done on such a topic. To further substantiate my arguments on the details of the medium itself, I interviewed students with experience in game design. Just as I do with art, while interacting with video games, I found myself experiencing tools and devices used by the artists to subconsciously direct my view, and found similarities in how I react to their visuals, and I wanted to further explore this effect while drawing parallels to popular art themes.

'Control' is a game that takes heavy inspiration from the 1950's Brutalist architecture movement, and combines them with supernatural themes, adding a mystical twist to the

[3] Museum of Modern Art, Pop Art, [Accessed 30th October 2021], https://www.moma.org/learn/moma_learning/themes/pop-art/

generally structured and daunting appearance of Brutalist buildings. The research in this essay will cover the historical context to the inspirations for the game, primarily brutalism and surrealism. Furthermore, I will be exploring the video game itself, dissecting its use of shape, colours, and form, and how these different elements come together to create a final artwork.

Historical Context to Visual Aesthetics

Brutalist Architecture

Bill Lebovich, East (partial view) and south elevations - Boston City Hall, One City Hall Square, Boston, Suffolk County, MA, Library of Congress, HABS MASS,13-BOST,71—6, 1981, https://www.loc.gov/pictures/item/ma1243.photos.076425p/

The origin for the term 'Brutalism' derives from the French word 'Béton brut'[4] which translates to 'raw concrete' and was a style of architecture that emerged in the 1950s and was used mainly for government projects, public centres, and high-density housing. Brutalist architecture was built on the ideas of socialism, to create reliable and affordable living spaces for everyone, and began as a symbol for utopianism. The style was popular in East European countries such as the Soviet Union, Czechoslovakia, Yugoslavia, etc.[5] The use of concrete is fundamental to the architectural style, as it was a cheap but sturdy material, and played a key role in both the philosophy and aesthetics of the style.

The key characteristics of brutalist architecture are its monolithic scales, unconventional geometry and monotone and rough textures. Although the style was introduced to provide security and housing to the masses, by the 1970's it came to symbolise oppression and control, due to its cold and unwelcoming appearance. Its frequented use in government buildings further emphasized this idea of repression, and the game explores this theme of irony, as art director Janne Pulkkinen puts it, "what started as a very utopian and idealistic architecture has become to represent oppression and bureaucracy and maybe a lot of negative things these days".[6]

Expanding on its geometric features, Brutalist architecture tends to emphasize its shapes by repeating its pattern, such as architect Carlos Scarpa, whose main motif included these repeating shapes, each one moving into the next, to create a sense of depth in the buildings.[7]

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[4] Royal Institute of British Architects, Brutalism, [Accessed 30th October 2021], https://www.architecture.com/explore-architecture/brutalism
[5] Designing Buildings, Brutalism, [Accessed 8th November 2021], https://www.designingbuildings.co.uk/wiki/Brutalism
[6] Polygon, Control taught me to love the ugliest architecture, [Accessed 30th September 2021], https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7n7ylXPueYE&t=444s
[7] Venice 2014, Creating Harmony Through Architecture: Brion Sanctuary at San Vito d'Altivole, [Accessed 8th November 2021], http://venice2014.org/exhibits/show/carlo-scarpa-brion-tomb/carlo-scarpa-conclusion

Surrealism

Introduced in the early 20th century, surrealism was a pioneer in breaking down the conventions of the perception of art, going beyond depictions of reality, instead of exploring the world of the unconscious. Coined by poet Guillaume Apollinaire, the word surrealism refers to 'beyond reality', and encourages the artist to explore their imagination. The underlying focus is to dive into the interpretation of the human psyche; hence the images are often obscure, with features that resemble reality, but there are no coherent laws or systems in the world itself, embracing the uncanny atmosphere of our dreams.[8]

Surrealism differentiates from the abstract as although neither provides a simple interpretation of its overarching subject, surrealism is far more grounded in reality than abstract art. The symbols and objects in surrealist art are often recognisable, using cultural and social context, however, are perceived from a distorted perspective, often using juxtaposition to create an absurdist setting.

The surrealist approach aims to transport you to a different world imbued with themes of mysticism and the subconscious and is a more experiential form of art. A classical and timeless example of surreal artwork is Salvador Dali's "The Persistence of Memory".[9] The art piece carries all the defining characteristics of surrealism. The melting watches; a warped reimagining of a common recognisable object from our reality, the background; intentionally obscure, with faint images of mountains and sea, similar to how dreamscapes work in our mind, taking inspiration from visuals in real life and combining them to create its reality. There

[8] Tate, Art Terms- Surrealism, [Accessed 30th October 2021], https://www.tate.org.uk/art/art-terms/s/surrealism
[9] Museum of Modern Art, Salvador Dali- The Persistence of Memory, [Accessed 30th October 2021], https://www.moma.org/collection/works/79018

is a hazy atmosphere to the entire image, lines blending into one another, and the perspective itself is misaligned.

Analysing Visual Design in Control

The Purpose of Shapes and Structure

Although set in the modern world of the 21st century, Control features a vintage aesthetic that resembles the bureaucratic offices of the 1960s. The game itself takes place in a fictional building in New York City known as the 'Oldest House', however, the inspiration for it comes from the city's 'Long Lines' building, formerly the AT&T Headquarters.[10] The windowless skyscraper has had a monolithic presence in New York since 1974, common in most brutalist architecture. The interior of the 'Oldest House' is ever-shifting and bends the laws of reality. Being a virtual space, the artists of 'Control' were not limited to physical restrictions, and the interiors span an area of far greater expanse than the building itself could realistically ever contain. This break from the real world forms the foundations for the surreal themes that centre the experience for the game itself. The building itself can be contrasted to a surreal artwork. They follow the same 'rules', or rather lack thereof, in terms of visual style and space.

[10] Eurogamer, Remedy's Control is Built on Concrete Foundations, [Accessed 27th October 2021], https://www.eurogamer.net/articles/2019-09-03-remedys-control-is-built-on-concrete-foundations

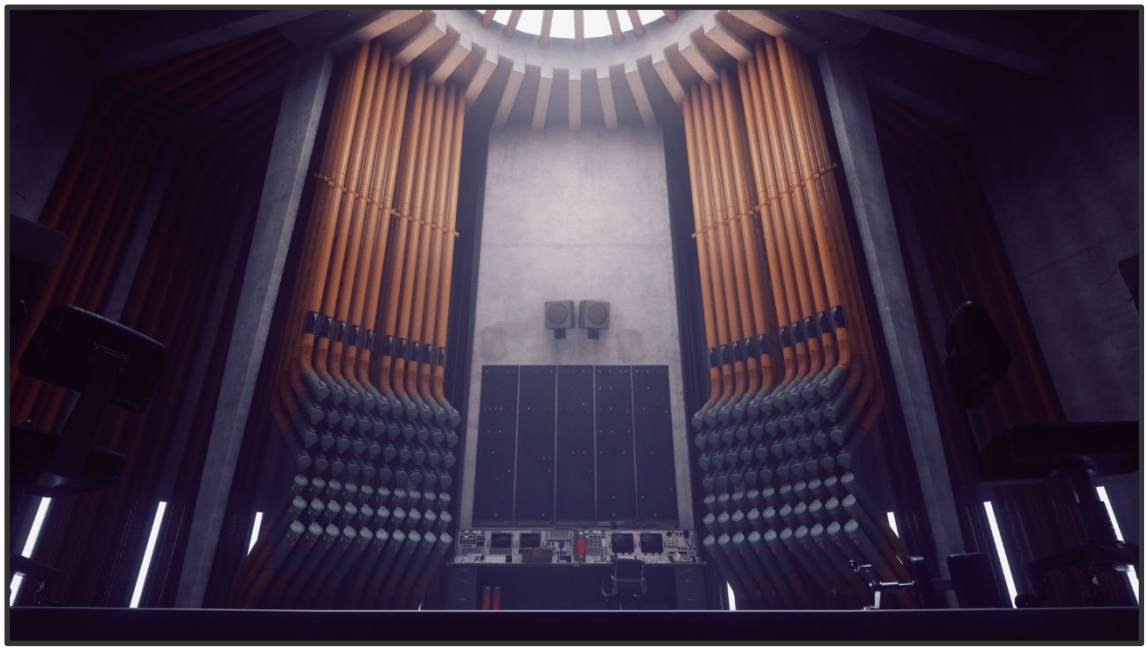
"There is a polarization at the heart of Brutalism — simplicity and freedom versus confinement and imprisonment. Love it or hate it, it's there, and it will always be there."[11]

Ayaan Ghoshal, screenshot from Control, 2021

The interiors themselves feature mid-20th-century furnishings and technology, further disconnecting the viewer from the world around them. The 'Oldest House' takes you back to a time of pneumatic tubes, punch cards, and monochrome CRT monitors. Although the props themselves aren't fictional, their use creates a timeless, otherworldly atmosphere, as they are memories of a time long gone.[12] As mentioned earlier, a key feature of surreal art is its inspiration from reality and warping it into a dreamlike landscape. Similarly, the game juxtaposes detailed set pieces against a blank, grey, concrete backdrop, creating a three-dimensional surreal world the viewer can move and interact with. The workspaces also contain a diversity of colours, in the green tinge of the monitors, the messy strew of

[11] Superjump, The Brutalist Paradise, [Accessed 4th October 2021], https://superjumpmagazine.com/the-brutalist-paradise-73ac6075400e
[12] Eurogamer, Control Review: Mid-century postmodernism, [Accessed 27th October 2021], https://www.eurogamer.net/articles/2019-08-23-control-review-mid-century-postmodernism

bureaucratic yellow folders or the red carpeting under the tables. The brutalist setting, on the other hand, concrete walls and jarring lines, detracts attention and only further accentuates the objects in the foreground.



Ayaan Ghoshal, screenshot from Control, 2021

The image above represents a perfect blend of ritual and administrative aesthetics. The room features a central light source, at the centre of its steep ceiling. The desk and screens at the centre form the main subject for the image. The pneumatic tubes create a flow upwards, accentuating the height of the ceiling itself. Although the set pieces are modern, the designers connect them to the theme of ritual by creating this ecclesiastical atmosphere to the structure. Because of the grey backdrop, every colour is immediately highlighted, similar to how the pristine, clean white walls of a church, empower the colours inside. This room holds a gothic aura, as the pneumatic tubes are symbolic of pipe organs, while the central desk forms the altar, and the contrast of lights and shadows draw attention to the centre.

All artwork is based on the fundamental rules of classical composition[13], the balance of the metaphorical 'weights' of different shapes, the line that forms the 'path' for the viewer's eyes, and the overall arrangement of its subjects, and these apply to all genres of art. When creating an artwork, beyond the colours, the artist must determine the structure, placement and composition of the image itself. Each facet must be deliberately placed, each playing its role in the overall direction of the artwork.

Dynamic Composition and its Effect on the Viewer

Although symmetry and organization are naturally appealing, art has a more successful response when that pattern is broken. In the monotonous structure of the office space, there is an irregularity in how the props are placed and they create a sense of unease as you see work desk after work desk of papers, typewriters, pens, pencils, all left behind as if their user just disappeared on the spot. These details build a story for the world in which it is contained, forming a larger image that serves both context and visuals for the viewer to experience. There is a structure in the placement of the desks, creating a satisfying array of neatly aligned rectangles, however, that pattern is broken by the smaller details, and prevent tiring the viewers' eyes from the otherwise monotonous picture.

As well as aesthetics, the composition is also responsible for directing the viewers' eyes in an image. To create the impression of flow and movement through an image, all compositions are built around a line which acts as a guideline for the viewer to follow across the image. Taking a titular example, in Michelangelo's 'Creation of Adam' the eye is directed from the left, Adam's figure, and moves across to the centre as his outstretched hand directs the viewer

[13] Tate, Art Terms- Composition, [Accessed 30th September 2021], https://www.tate.org.uk/art/art-terms/c/composition

upwards, till where it connects with the God's hand on the opposite end of the canvas. It leads to His figure, and the shape of the brain in which He sits in is revealed. These constructions are subconscious, and although at first glance are not apparent, give the viewer the impression that they are in control of their viewing experience. Drawing parallels to the three-dimensional environment, the task of the level designers is to direct the player through them while allowing them to take in the effort put in as well. We see examples of dynamic composition everywhere in our daily lives. Whether they exist in road signs directing us to addresses, or even queues in a store marked by tape, although they go unnoticed, these compositional elements are constantly used to direct us into places. However, while a road sign holds both function and purpose in a busy intersection, the same cannot be said for a bureaucratic office space.

Ayaan Ghoshal, screenshot from Control, 2021

Now combining the rules of structure and dynamic composition,[14] we can analyse how the artist directs the viewer through their physical space. The use of the single point perspective

[14] Gamedeveloper, The Aesthetics of Game Art and Game Design, [Accessed September 30th 2021], https://www.gamedeveloper.com/design/the-aesthetics-of-game-art-and-game-design

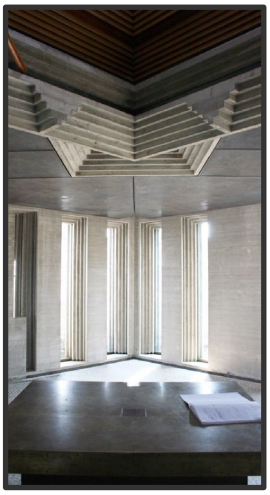
immediately directs the viewer to the centre of the image, which is where the exit lies. Although the freedom is given to the viewer to explore all axes of this space, they are driven to the end of the room. There are no apparent arrows or displays which hint at the direction to the viewer, but it is instinctively understood that progress lies straight ahead. There are multiple lines across the room that all converge towards its centre. However, once again, the orange pneumatic tubes protruding upwards, direct the viewer to its imposing structure and give it a sense of scale. However, as much as rigidity and strict lines compose the whole image, smaller props and details are intentionally added to let the viewer stop and linger across the space. Papers strewn on the otherwise spotless, mirrorlike floor, bright red canisters, and abandoned mail bags break up the harshness of the cold concrete.

Themes

Rituals in World Design and Architecture

A motif in the game is the theme of rituals, the idea that life is governed and propagated by routine. When the viewer moves through this space, they will notice recurring patterns in the concrete walls that surround them. Brutalist architecture heavily emphasizes its shapes and lines, allowing the artist to create fascinating geometric patterns. Carlos Scarpa is one such architect who understood this advantage of his concrete medium and was a pioneer in exploring the idea of repetition in his works. His patterns are built by inlaying shapes one inside the other, lowly shifting inside, and creating stepped patterns that add a sense of depth to his walls. For ‘Control’ this inspiration can be seen within its shifting walls, where the artists

take heavy inspiration from Scarpa and take it a step further by breathing life into it.[15] Although restricted by its geometry, the spaces still move organically, almost as if it was living itself.



Andrea Tornabene, Tomba Brion (S.Vito d'Altivole), Flickr, 2008, https://www.flickr.com/photos/frammenti/2950089466/, https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.0/

The shifting walls also come from the narrative point that the building is corrupted. The corruption is by the colour red, and the objective of the player is to 'cleanse' the building itself. To do so, the character goes through a supernatural ritual and is repeated through the game. The setting of the bureau itself further accentuates the idea of ritual, as the formalities and punctuality of the office space that is constantly bound by its rituals.[16]

[15] Design Detail, Control: Graphic Brutalism, [Accessed 8th November 2021], http://designdetail.in/control-graphic-brutalism/

[16] Gamedeveloper, The Real Buildings that Inspired Control's Oldest House, [Accessed October 4th 2021], https://www.gamedeveloper.com/art/the-real-buildings-that-inspired-i-control-i-s-oldest-house

Ayaan Ghoshal, screenshot from Control, 2021

As seen in its composition, the earlier images resembled the aesthetics and form of a church, which symbolises the ritualistic theme present. The image above exemplifies the influence of Scarpa on the structure of the walls. The stepped floor reflects the similar inset of the wall above. the pillars themselves have the same pattern, where the shapes are one inside the other. The design of the room seems almost sacred, with the central figure of the black pyramid, itself representing a religious figure.

Ayaan Ghoshal, screenshot from Control, 2021

This is the same room before being 'cleansed', and the supernatural effect of its corruption is apparent to the viewer. The extreme red contrasted with the shadows signals danger and creates an apprehension in the viewer. Even the walls themselves, which still have the thematic stepped aesthetic, are a lot more violent and aggressive as even in its rigidity it seems to follow no apparent rule, unlike the preceding image. The room is still the same, but it transforms around the viewer as they interact with the artwork itself. The two images use the same style of Brutalist architecture; however, the implementation creates two extremely polar effects on the viewer. The same repetitive patterns which created a sense of perfection and balance, are used here to depict violence and disruption, with only a minor tweak in the rules. The lack of symmetry asserts a completely different response from the viewer.

Exploring Dreamscapes and the Subconscious using the Medium

The game also takes you in between two parallel worlds, the 'Astral Plane' and the characters reality. The Plane acts as a physical manifestation of the character's mind and explores the theme of the human psyche, and the Jungian concept of synchronicity, that all meaningful occurrences have an underlying cause, and suggests that the characters influence in the 'Astral Plane' their subconscious, has a relative effect in their world. [17]

Being a 'dreamscape', the aesthetics of the 'Astral Plane' take heavy influence from surreal artworks. The background is a blank, foggy void, and the landscapes consist of blackish gold structures, with no recognisable form. Surreal art takes the ideas of the absurd and tries to visualise the inside of a mind. The game's interpretation of this subject does the same, going

[17] Control Wiki, Astral Plane, [Accessed November 8th 2021], https://control.fandom.com/wiki/Astral_Plane

beyond reality, using obscure details with no coherent meaning but rather focusing on the reaction of its viewer.

The air is thick, as objects farther away fade away, and in its undefined horizon silhouettes of similar structures like the ones around you expand far beyond and create this sense of isolation. Movements in these sections are much slower because there is no immediate threat or loud dynamic compositions propelling you forwards. In contrast to the real world, it's much more simple, soft, and empty, giving the viewer a breathing space. These points act as a moment of self-reflection, as most of the significant developments occur here. It being a video game, progression in the form of upgrades to the character's strength occur here, where the player is rewarded for their actions in the real world.

This alternate dimension holds a symbolic value in self-reflection. Where in other forms of art and media, the viewer never personally relates to the characters depicted in them, in games you control the actions of the main character. As mentioned earlier, no other medium allows this level of relationship to the work itself, so the surreal imagery here is very thought-provoking for someone playing through the game.

In the background, the pyramid reappears once again, and is a constant throughout the 'Astral Plane' but is never reachable, and we still recognise the imposing geometric shapes of the Brutalist architecture of the world outside, however, they have lost their characteristic features and exist more as silhouettes of the concrete structures. The concept of real-world objects existing in surreal imagery stems from its definition of the 'dreamscapes'. When we see dreams, they are often a recollection of our experiences and memories, and details are often lost to more abstract imagery. A notion of synchronicity[18] is that the 'inner world', our

[18] Jankowski, K. Jung's Synchronicity Principle (In a Few Words), [Accessed November 8th 2021], https://www.researchgate.net/publication/343319321_JUNG%27S_SYNCHRONICITY_PRINCIPLE_IN_A_FEW_WORDS

subconscious, plays a role in the events we experience, as it affects our behaviour and interactions. The game derives from this concept, and taking it further with its rules of fiction, and expresses that they are interconnected and that to create change one must first manifest change within themselves, a common introspection in surreal art. Surrealism is closely linked to psychology, and 'Control' demonstrates this theme by contrasting the real and the surreal within the same media.

Artem Feodoroff, Environment Art, ArtStation, Remedy Entertainment, 2019, https://www.artstation.com/artwork/RYZvJr

In the image above, you can see that it is quite empty, in contrast to the heavily detailed sets of the real world. Art encourages you to ponder and take a moment to think about the subject it tries to express. Art is highly rated when it is the most subjective and allows its viewer to carry their interpretation of what they have seen. Although the viewer is given context and

dialogue briefly introducing the 'Astral Plane', there is no objective definition of what it truly represents. As narrative designer Brooke Maggs quotes "There is a lot of mystery surrounding the Astral Plane, which we want to keep".[19]

Interview with Game Developers

An interview a group of college-level students from the Griffith Film School, creators of the game 'Necrosis State High' conducted for this paper, gave multiple insights into the process of developing and creating a video game.

A common point discussed between the team was that "games are a really interesting way to tell a story". Understanding the method of creating and engaging the viewer and developing a relationship between the artist and their audience, and visual cues that aid to a theme or message that the artist wants to express. They pointed out that communicating the story was essential to designing a game, and it cannot solely rely on text-based exposition, so the setting and the narrative must work together, and it relies on the viewer being able to read details to piece the story together.

Control's visual design reflects on these points. Although it does contain dialogue and text, a majority of the themes and ideas are explored visually, giving the viewer the power to take away their own interpretation of the work. As the lead programmer mentioned, "it immerses you in the character's world", and gives you the time and space to experience the artwork.

[19] Game Informer, Remedy Breaks Down One of Control's Biggest Mysteries: The Astral Plane, [Accessed November 8th 2021], https://www.gameinformer.com/2019/03/29/remedy-breaks-down-one-of-controls-big-mysteries-the-astral-plane

Conclusion

The Extended Essay assessed the media as any form of art, exploring its cultural context, its visual appeal and designs, and its symbolism and themes. An objective definition of the visual arts would be any form of imagery that applies technical skill and creativity, that provokes a response from its aesthetic and its themes.

‘Control’ falls into this category, utilizing the technical skill required for composition, form, structure, colour theory and shapes, and the creators exhibit a key understanding in Brutalism and Surrealism, its foundations and ideologies, and how they connect to the overall experience for the viewer. Art cannot be created in isolation from the world around it, and ‘Control’ takes inspiration from real-life materials and sources to express itself. The influence of Brutalism has been assimilated into both the visuals and theme of the game itself. Not only does it hold visual context, but it takes the historic and cultural elements of the architectural style as well. It understands what Brutalism represented at its foundation and what it has come to represent today, and even goes as far as to utilise its change in perception as a metaphor for its themes. The value of the surreal aspect is also the same, as it takes both aesthetic and contextual meaning, using its rules to create heavy and pondering atmospheres, but also its foundations in psychology, and the exploration of the human mind.

Art exists in both two dimensional and three-dimensional spaces, the prior being limited to a single perspective, but having the advantage of bending real-world rules of physics and space, while the latter allows the freedom of visual perspective, but is limited by physical laws. As a videogame, ‘Control’ surpasses these two restrictions, as the medium allows the artist and

viewer the freedom of movement and lack of physical limitations. In doing so, the viewer's experience is far more interactive, and become a part of the artwork itself.

Therefore, I would like to conclude by giving a definitive scale of the extent 'Control' goes to as a visual experience. Art is in a constant state of evolution and change, and critics have always existed to refute new forthcoming ideas challenging the definitions of art, and 'Control' is an example of how video games are doing the same today. Instead of refuting it as a possibility, it is important to explore the opportunities of a new medium. As the current generation is defined by technology today, video games as an artistic medium are simply a reflection of our current time, just as modern art was defined by the Industrial era.

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